the entire area will remain green and open. The city plans to have only 60,000 residents—200 people per hectare—while creating 100,000+ jobs. Unlike latter-day boomtowns with their virtual class apartheid, a quarter of its 16,000 homes will be affordable. Singapore-based Subarna Jurong will prepare the detailed project report.

Takeaways

- **The city is to have an innovation hub, inclusive housing, 47% green area**
- **Private investors will be roped in to fund half of the Rs 8,179 crore project**



Setting up 10.4 million sq. ft of housing, 6.5 million sq. ft of commercial area and 2.4 million sq. ft of MICE infra is projected to cost about Rs 8,179 crore. The guidelines have yet to be inked, but a three-way cost-sharing is planned: 25 per cent from the Centre, 25 per cent from the state, 50 per cent from private investors whom Odisha plans to seduce with attractive clauses. "If hospitality or business investments come in, the land can be cross-subsidised," explains a senior official. "The idea is, the government builds the core infrastructure—roads, lighting, utilities—and private partners handle long-term maintenance and services. That way, the city doesn't just get built; it sustains itself." The Odisha cabinet has approved a five-year funding window for the project, laying the foundation for its first phase.

SYMBIOTICALLY LINKED

Complementing the new city will be redevelopment in the old one, says Usha Padhee, principal secretary, housing and urban development. "Bhubaneswar is a heritage city; we have to be very careful with it. Every city grows—more people, more commerce, more movement. It's better to plan a solution before problems arrive." One plan centres around the railway station, which is itself being modernised. The idea is to have a commercial hub enveloping the station area.

All this sounds picture-perfect—on paper. In reality, nothing starts from a pristine blank slate. An existing order has to be disturbed. "The proposed town borders the city's vital green buffer—the Chandaka forest. Bhubaneswar, India's first planned capital, was designed to coexist with nature. This project risks that harmony," says urban planner Piyush Ranjan Rout.

He raises a basic question. "Globally, new cities like Incheon or Putrajaya once symbolised ambition, but often they become escapes from fixing existing urban issues, as also seen in Egypt and Indonesia's new capitals. For Bhubaneswar, the question is: has it truly reached saturation, or are we ignoring its revival?" Königsberger, too, worked on an old site. A city with a 2,000-year past thus ponders its futures. ■

▶ TAMIL NADU

Saffron's Southern Paradox

DMK aims arrows at BJP's 'love-hate' relation with TN

By **Kavitha Muralidharan**

AS INDIA'S POLITY NAVIGATES YET ANOTHER cycle of electoral rhetoric, Tamil Nadu has acquired a curious duality for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP): it is a name, an idea, an entity that's at once desired and demonised. To be more precise, Tamil Nadu is mocked outside its borders, and courted at home. This split in the saffron political imagination has not gone unnoticed within the ruling DMK, as Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent campaign speeches supplied fresh evidence. While the Dravidian party is his primary target, it's swooping down on remarks that have a strain of generalisation in order to poison-tip its own arrows.

Modi's barbs have been sharp too. In Bihar, for instance, he accused the DMK government of mistreating Bihari migrant



TOTEM AND TABOO? The PM invokes the *sengol* as a national symbol